

Lab: Discovering Your Inventor Archetype

Objective

Identify your own inventor archetype by examining your prior beliefs, precision weightings, preferred action policies, and motivational profile. Then practice adopting a complementary archetype to expand your creative repertoire. By the end of this lab, you will have a concrete self-assessment and a strategy for leveraging your strengths while compensating for your blind spots.

Materials / Prerequisites

- Your own invention idea or project (any domain, any stage)
- Paper and pen for sketching
- A timer
- Completed reading of Module 02: The Creative Agent

Part 1: Map Your Generative Model (15 minutes)

Your generative model is everything you believe about how the world works, what needs exist, and what solutions are possible. Most of this model is implicit — you operate on assumptions you have never explicitly stated. This exercise makes parts of that model visible. When you can see your assumptions, you can evaluate them, update them, and identify the ones that might be wrong. The goal is not to judge your beliefs but to catalog them, because awareness of your own model is the first step toward managing it deliberately. Pay special attention to beliefs you hold with high confidence — these are your strongest priors, and they are both your greatest asset and your most likely blind spot.

Step 1 (5 min): Consider your invention idea. List your core beliefs about the problem you are trying to solve. These are your priors — the assumptions you bring to the creative process.

Belief / Assumption	Confidence Level (1-10)	Source (Education / Experience / Intuition / Data)

Write your response here

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Step 2 (5 min): Now list beliefs about your solution approach — what you assume about how the problem should be solved:

Solution Assumption	Confidence Level (1-10)	What Would Change If This Were Wrong?

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Write your response here

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Write your response here

Step 3 (5 min): Identify your three strongest beliefs (highest confidence) and your three weakest. What does this pattern tell you about where your model is well-calibrated versus where you are operating on assumption?

Strongest beliefs:

Write your response here

Weakest beliefs:

Write your response here

What this pattern reveals:

Write your response here

Part 2: Identify Your Archetype (12 minutes)

The four inventor archetypes — Methodical Engineer, Tinkerer, Accidental Discoverer, and Systems Thinker — are not rigid categories but tendencies. Most inventors are blends, with a primary archetype that dominates their default approach and secondary tendencies that emerge in specific situations. The value of identifying your archetype is not to label yourself permanently but to understand your default settings — the assumptions, priorities, and approaches you fall back on when you are not consciously choosing a strategy. Once you know your default, you can deliberately choose to override it when the situation calls for a different approach.

Step 1 (6 min): Rate yourself on each dimension below. Be honest — there are no right answers.

Dimension	Scale	Your Rating
When facing a new problem, I prefer to analyze before building vs. build to understand	1 (analyze first) — 10 (build first)	

Write your response here

|| I trust theoretical reasoning vs. empirical testing | 1 (theory) — 10 (empirical) |

Write your response here

|| I focus deeply on one domain vs. draw from many domains | 1 (deep) — 10 (broad) |

Write your response here

|| I am motivated by solving a specific problem vs. exploring what is possible | 1 (problem-focused) — 10 (exploration-focused) |

Write your response here

|| I prefer refining an existing solution vs. generating entirely new approaches | 1 (refine) — 10 (generate new) |

Write your response here

|| I work best alone vs. in dialogue with others | 1 (alone) — 10 (with others) |

Write your response here

|| When I encounter something unexpected, I investigate it vs. stay on track | 1 (stay on track) — 10 (investigate) |

Write your response here

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Step 2 (6 min): Based on your ratings, which archetype(s) best describe you? You may be a blend.

- **Methodical Engineer:** Low scores on 2, 5, 7; high scores on 1 (analyze side)
- **Tinkerer:** High scores on 2, 5; low scores on 1 (build side)
- **Accidental Discoverer:** High scores on 3, 7; moderate on others
- **Systems Thinker:** High scores on 3, 4; often moderate across others

My primary archetype:

Write your response here

My secondary archetype (if applicable):

Write your response here

How this archetype has shaped my past creative work (give a specific example):

Write your response here

Part 3: Identify Your Blind Spots (10 minutes)

Every inventor archetype has characteristic blind spots — regions of the solution space that are systematically invisible because the archetype's generative model does not predict observations from those regions. The Methodical Engineer may miss solutions that require artistic intuition. The Tinkerer may miss solutions that require formal analysis. The Accidental Discoverer may miss solutions that require sustained systematic effort. Identifying your blind spots is uncomfortable but essential — it is the difference between unconscious bias and deliberate modeling. The following exercise asks you to confront what you are most likely to miss.

Step 1 (5 min): Every archetype has characteristic blind spots. Based on your archetype, identify what you are likely to miss:

My Archetype Tendency	What It Causes Me to Miss	A Time This Actually Happened

Write your response here

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Write your response here

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Write your response here

Write your response here

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Step 2 (5 min): For your invention idea, identify one specific blind spot that your archetype creates. What aspect of the problem or solution space are you not seeing because of your priors?

The blind spot:

Write your response here

Why my priors cause this blind spot:

Write your response here

What an inventor with a different archetype would see here:

Write your response here

Part 4: Adopt a Complementary Archetype (15 minutes)

One of the most powerful techniques for expanding your creative capacity is to deliberately adopt a different inventor archetype — to think about your problem through a lens that is not your natural default. This is cognitively demanding because it requires temporarily reducing the precision of your habitual priors and increasing the precision of unfamiliar ones. Think of it as method acting for inventors: you are not pretending to be a different person, but you are deliberately adopting a different set of assumptions, priorities, and approaches to see what they reveal about your problem.

Step 1 (5 min): Choose the archetype most different from yours. For the next ten minutes, you will deliberately think about your invention idea from this perspective. Before you begin, describe how this archetype would approach your invention:

Archetype I am adopting:

Write your response here

How this archetype would frame my problem:

Write your response here

What this archetype would prioritize:

Write your response here

Step 2 (10 min): Spend ten minutes working on your invention idea from this new perspective. Write, sketch, or diagram whatever emerges. The goal is not to produce a polished idea but to explore territory your default archetype would not visit.

What emerged from adopting the complementary archetype:

Write your response here

Was anything genuinely surprising or useful? What?

Write your response here

What will you carry forward from this exercise?

Write your response here

Part 5: Design Your Creative Team (8 minutes)

Step 1 (4 min): If you were building a team of 3-4 people to develop your invention, what archetypes would you recruit? Why?

Role	Archetype	What They Bring	How They Complement You
You			

Write your response here

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Write your response here

| — || Teammate 1 |

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Write your response here

|| Teammate 2 |

Write your response here

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Write your response here

| | Teammate 3 |

Write your response here

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Write your response here

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Write your response here

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Step 2 (4 min): What shared artifacts (prototypes, documents, diagrams) would this team need to communicate across their different generative models? List at least three:

1.

Write your response here

1.

Write your response here

1.

Write your response here

How would you ensure the team maintains enough model diversity to avoid groupthink while staying aligned enough to make progress?

Write your response here

Discussion / Debrief Questions

1. Did the archetype self-assessment surprise you, or did it confirm what you already knew? What was the most informative dimension?

2. When you adopted the complementary archetype in Part 4, did it feel uncomfortable, liberating, or both? What does that tell you about the flexibility of your generative model?
3. In what situations is it most important to be aware of your archetype? When are your default tendencies most helpful, and when are they most limiting?
4. How does the concept of "precision weighting" help explain disagreements in creative teams? Think of a time when you disagreed with a collaborator — can you reframe that disagreement as a difference in precision weighting rather than a difference in values?
5. The module discusses the accidental discoverer as someone who notices anomalies that others dismiss. How can you cultivate this capacity regardless of your primary archetype? What practices or habits might help?